



BOUND TO DO NO INJURY TO FELLOW-CREATURES

THE CRUELTY TO ANIMALS ACT (1849)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Animal welfare law

BEFORE

1764 In “Bêtes” (“Beasts”), an entry in his *Dictionnaire Philosophique*, Voltaire argues that animals are sentient.

1822 The first national law against animal cruelty is passed, in the UK.

1835 Revised British animal cruelty laws ban cockfighting and bull- and badger-baiting.

AFTER

1911 The Protection of Animals Act extends cruelty laws to cover all animals.

2006 The UK Animal Welfare Act makes owners responsible for ensuring their animals have a suitable environment and diet and protection from injury, disease, and suffering.

2019 In the US, extreme animal cruelty becomes a federal crime.

Historically, people had viewed animals either as wild forces of nature, imbued with magical or even demonic powers, or as property. By the 17th century, some people had begun to recognize that animals needed legal protection from unnecessary suffering. In 1635, the Parliament of Ireland passed an “Act against Plowing by the Tayle, and Pulling the Wooll off Living Sheep” to prevent the Gaelic Irish

practices of attaching a plow to a horse's tail and tearing wool from a sheep's back. In New England, too, the Massachusetts Body of Liberties (1641), one of the first legal codes in America to set out people's rights and responsibilities, included rules against “Tirranny or Crueltie” toward domestic animals—any specifically kept “for man's use.”

In the 18th century, as the ideas of the Enlightenment gathered pace in Europe, there was a growing

The **Enlightenment** promotes the idea that **animals feel** and **therefore suffer**.

Christians feel a growing **moral duty** to **prevent the suffering** of animals.



Legal protection is initially extended only to **economically important** farm animals.



Lobbying by the **Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals** increases **public awareness of animal suffering**, and the Cruelty to Animals Act passes.